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QGD Exchange and Carlsbad Structures

Minority attacks, central e4 plans, move orders, and structural decisions

COURSE BOOK

20 focused chapters - model positions - decision rules - retrieval practice

Designed to change what you notice, calculate, remember, and do at the board.

How to Use This Course

ONE CHAPTER, FOUR PASSES

1. Read the position without moving pieces. 2. State your plan and the opponent's counterplay. 3. Study the decision rules. 4. Close the book and reconstruct the position from memory.

RETRIEVAL SCHEDULE

Review the chapter the next day, one week later, and after a game that reaches a similar structure. Retrieval is more valuable than rereading.

BOARD ROUTINE

Opponent's threat - forcing moves - loose pieces - worst piece - central break - best reply - choose and stop.

The course book explains each model position. The separate workbook forces recall, prediction, and self-scoring. Use the book first, then attempt the matching workbook page without looking back.

Engine evaluations are intentionally not the lesson. The aim is to store human decision rules that remain useful when the exact move order changes.

Course Map

MODULE	CHAPTERS
QGD EXCHANGE AND CARLSBAD	20

01. QGD Exchange with Nge2



QGD EXCHANGE AND CARLSBAD

READ THE POSITION

White chooses the flexible Nge2 setup, keeping the f-pawn available for a central or kingside expansion.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use f3, Rae1, and central support when Black is passive.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...c5: Black challenges the center and may equalize quickly.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bg5 Be7 6. e3 O-O 7. Bd3 Nbd7 8. Qc2 Re8 9. Nge2 Nf8 10. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Nge2 preserves f3 and points toward e4; choose that plan consciously.

01. Decision Framework

QGD Exchange with Nge2

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	White chooses the flexible Nge2 setup, keeping the f-pawn available for a central or kingside expansion.
PIECE JOB	The e2-knight earns its place through g3, f4 or c1; it should support e4 rather than remain a spectator.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not push b-pawns and f-pawns without choosing a theater.
TRADE FILTER	Preserve pieces that support e4 and trade defenders of the dark squares only when the center will open in White's favor.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Choose one theater-central expansion or minority attack-and make every piece support that choice before advancing pawns. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not push b-pawns and f-pawns without choosing a theater.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Nge2 preserves f3 and points toward e4; choose that plan consciously.

02. QGD Exchange with Nge2



QGD EXCHANGE AND CARLSBAD

READ THE POSITION

White chooses the flexible Nge2 setup, keeping the f-pawn available for a central or kingside expansion.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use f3, Rae1, and central support when Black is passive.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...c5: Black challenges the center and may equalize quickly.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bg5 Be7 6. e3 O-O 7. Bd3 Nbd7 8. Qc2 Re8 9. Nge2 Nf8 10. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Nge2 preserves f3 and points toward e4; choose that plan consciously.

02. Decision Framework

QGD Exchange with Nge2

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	White chooses the flexible Nge2 setup, keeping the f-pawn available for a central or kingside expansion.
PIECE JOB	The e2-knight earns its place through g3, f4 or c1; it should support e4 rather than remain a spectator.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not push b-pawns and f-pawns without choosing a theater.
TRADE FILTER	Preserve pieces that support e4 and trade defenders of the dark squares only when the center will open in White's favor.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Choose one theater-central expansion or minority attack-and make every piece support that choice before advancing pawns. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not push b-pawns and f-pawns without choosing a theater.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Nge2 preserves f3 and points toward e4; choose that plan consciously.

03. QGD Exchange with Nge2



QGD EXCHANGE AND CARLSBAD

READ THE POSITION

White chooses the flexible Nge2 setup, keeping the f-pawn available for a central or kingside expansion.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use f3, Rae1, and central support when Black is passive.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...c5: Black challenges the center and may equalize quickly.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bg5 Be7 6. e3 O-O 7. Bd3 Nbd7 8. Qc2 Re8 9. Nge2 Nf8 10. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Nge2 preserves f3 and points toward e4; choose that plan consciously.

03. Decision Framework

QGD Exchange with Nge2

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	White chooses the flexible Nge2 setup, keeping the f-pawn available for a central or kingside expansion.
PIECE JOB	The e2-knight earns its place through g3, f4 or c1; it should support e4 rather than remain a spectator.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not push b-pawns and f-pawns without choosing a theater.
TRADE FILTER	Preserve pieces that support e4 and trade defenders of the dark squares only when the center will open in White's favor.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Choose one theater-central expansion or minority attack-and make every piece support that choice before advancing pawns. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not push b-pawns and f-pawns without choosing a theater.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Nge2 preserves f3 and points toward e4; choose that plan consciously.

04. QGD Exchange with Nf3



QGD EXCHANGE AND CARLSBAD

READ THE POSITION

The Nf3 Exchange setup favors reliable development and the classic queenside minority attack.

PRIMARY PLAN

Prepare a3, Rab1, b4, and b5.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Ne4: Black trades pieces and reduces queenside pressure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Nf3 c6 6. Bg5 Be7 7. Qc2 O-O 8. e3 Nbd7 9. Bd3 Re8 10. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Nf3 means dependable development and a queenside minority plan.

04. Decision Framework

QGD Exchange with Nf3

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	The Nf3 Exchange setup favors reliable development and the classic queenside minority attack.
PIECE JOB	The f3-knight supports a reliable center while rooks and queen prepare the queenside files created by b4-b5.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not launch b4 if Black's central break is faster.
TRADE FILTER	Trade the dark-squared bishops when it improves access to c5 and c7; avoid exchanges that relieve all pressure on c6.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Create the c6 weakness with b5, fix it, then transfer pieces to the c-file instead of expecting the pawn push to win by itself. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not launch b4 if Black's central break is faster.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Nf3 means dependable development and a queenside minority plan.

05. QGD Exchange with Nf3



QGD EXCHANGE AND CARLSBAD

READ THE POSITION

The Nf3 Exchange setup favors reliable development and the classic queenside minority attack.

PRIMARY PLAN

Prepare a3, Rab1, b4, and b5.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Ne4: Black trades pieces and reduces queenside pressure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Nf3 c6 6. Bg5 Be7 7. Qc2 O-O 8. e3 Nbd7 9. Bd3 Re8 10. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Nf3 means dependable development and a queenside minority plan.

05. Decision Framework

QGD Exchange with Nf3

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	The Nf3 Exchange setup favors reliable development and the classic queenside minority attack.
PIECE JOB	The f3-knight supports a reliable center while rooks and queen prepare the queenside files created by b4-b5.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not launch b4 if Black's central break is faster.
TRADE FILTER	Trade the dark-squared bishops when it improves access to c5 and c7; avoid exchanges that relieve all pressure on c6.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Create the c6 weakness with b5, fix it, then transfer pieces to the c-file instead of expecting the pawn push to win by itself. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not launch b4 if Black's central break is faster.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Nf3 means dependable development and a queenside minority plan.

06. QGD Exchange with Nf3



QGD EXCHANGE AND CARLSBAD

READ THE POSITION

The Nf3 Exchange setup favors reliable development and the classic queenside minority attack.

PRIMARY PLAN

Prepare a3, Rab1, b4, and b5.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Ne4: Black trades pieces and reduces queenside pressure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Nf3 c6 6. Bg5 Be7 7. Qc2 O-O 8. e3 Nbd7 9. Bd3 Re8 10. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Nf3 means dependable development and a queenside minority plan.

06. Decision Framework

QGD Exchange with Nf3

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	The Nf3 Exchange setup favors reliable development and the classic queenside minority attack.
PIECE JOB	The f3-knight supports a reliable center while rooks and queen prepare the queenside files created by b4-b5.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not launch b4 if Black's central break is faster.
TRADE FILTER	Trade the dark-squared bishops when it improves access to c5 and c7; avoid exchanges that relieve all pressure on c6.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Create the c6 weakness with b5, fix it, then transfer pieces to the c-file instead of expecting the pawn push to win by itself. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not launch b4 if Black's central break is faster.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Nf3 means dependable development and a queenside minority plan.

07. Carlsbad Structure Laboratory



QGD EXCHANGE AND CARLSBAD

READ THE POSITION

White has the c- and d-pawn exchange fixed and usually attacks the queenside with fewer pawns.

PRIMARY PLAN

White's b-pawn creates the weakness; rooks, knights and queen must attack it afterward.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Ne4: Black trades pieces and reduces queenside pressure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Nf3 c6 6. Bg5 Be7 7. Qc2 O-O 8. e3 Nbd7 9. Bd3 Re8 10. O-O

MEMORY RULE

The minority attack creates a target; pieces, not pawns, finish the job.

07. Decision Framework

Carlsbad Structure Laboratory

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	White has the c- and d-pawn exchange fixed and usually attacks the queenside with fewer pawns. Black seeks ...c5 or ...e5 to avoid defending a static c6 weakness. White's b-pawn creates the weakness; rooks, knights and queen must attack it afterward.
PIECE JOB	The f3-knight supports a reliable center while rooks and queen prepare the queenside files created by b4-b5.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not trade every rook before the newly opened c-file can be used.
TRADE FILTER	Keep pieces that can enter c5, c6 or c7 after b4-b5. Exchange a defender when the c-file target remains and cannot be repaired. Trade the dark-squared bishops when it improves access to c5 and c7; avoid exchanges that relieve all pressure on c6.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Fix the c6 pawn before simplifying. Bring the king toward the queenside once central breaks are controlled. Create a second weakness if Black can defend c6 with one piece.
CLOCK RULE	Do not trade every rook before the newly opened c-file can be used.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: The minority attack creates a target; pieces, not pawns, finish the job.

08. Carlsbad Structure Laboratory - Endgames



QGD EXCHANGE AND CARLSBAD

READ THE POSITION

White has the c- and d-pawn exchange fixed and usually attacks the queenside with fewer pawns.

PRIMARY PLAN

White's b-pawn creates the weakness; rooks, knights and queen must attack it afterward.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Ne4: Black trades pieces and reduces queenside pressure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Nf3 c6 6. Bg5 Be7 7. Qc2 O-O 8. e3 Nbd7 9. Bd3 Re8 10. O-O

MEMORY RULE

The minority attack creates a target; pieces, not pawns, finish the job.

08. Decision Framework

Carlsbad Structure Laboratory - Endgames

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	White has the c- and d-pawn exchange fixed and usually attacks the queenside with fewer pawns. Black seeks ...c5 or ...e5 to avoid defending a static c6 weakness. White's b-pawn creates the weakness; rooks, knights and queen must attack it afterward.
PIECE JOB	The f3-knight supports a reliable center while rooks and queen prepare the queenside files created by b4-b5.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not trade every rook before the newly opened c-file can be used.
TRADE FILTER	Keep pieces that can enter c5, c6 or c7 after b4-b5. Exchange a defender when the c-file target remains and cannot be repaired. Trade the dark-squared bishops when it improves access to c5 and c7; avoid exchanges that relieve all pressure on c6.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Fix the c6 pawn before simplifying. Bring the king toward the queenside once central breaks are controlled. Create a second weakness if Black can defend c6 with one piece.
CLOCK RULE	Do not trade every rook before the newly opened c-file can be used.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: The minority attack creates a target; pieces, not pawns, finish the job.

09. QGD Exchange with Nge2 - Move-Order Lab



QGD EXCHANGE AND CARLSBAD

READ THE POSITION

White chooses the flexible Nge2 setup, keeping the f-pawn available for a central or kingside expansion.

PRIMARY PLAN

Nge2 preserves f3 and points toward e4; choose that plan consciously.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...c5: Black challenges the center and may equalize quickly.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bg5 Be7 6. e3 O-O 7. Bd3 Nbd7 8. Qc2 Re8 9. Nge2 Nf8 10. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Reconstruct the line and name the first move-order fork.

09. Decision Framework

QGD Exchange with Nge2 - Move-Order Lab

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	White chooses the flexible Nge2 setup, keeping the f-pawn available for a central or kingside expansion.
PIECE JOB	The e2-knight earns its place through g3, f4 or c1; it should support e4 rather than remain a spectator.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not push b-pawns and f-pawns without choosing a theater.
TRADE FILTER	Preserve pieces that support e4 and trade defenders of the dark squares only when the center will open in White's favor.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Choose one theater-central expansion or minority attack-and make every piece support that choice before advancing pawns. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not push b-pawns and f-pawns without choosing a theater.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Reconstruct the line and name the first move-order fork.

10. QGD Exchange with Nge2 - Plan Lab



QGD EXCHANGE AND CARLSBAD

READ THE POSITION

Use f3, Rae1, and central support when Black is passive.

PRIMARY PLAN

The e2-knight earns its place through g3, f4 or c1; it should support e4 rather than remain a spectator.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...c5: Black challenges the center and may equalize quickly.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bg5 Be7 6. e3 O-O 7. Bd3 Nbd7 8. Qc2 Re8 9. Nge2 Nf8 10. O-O

MEMORY RULE

State White's plan, Black's best counterplay, and the piece that must improve first.

10. Decision Framework

QGD Exchange with Nge2 - Plan Lab

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	White chooses the flexible Nge2 setup, keeping the f-pawn available for a central or kingside expansion.
PIECE JOB	The e2-knight earns its place through g3, f4 or c1; it should support e4 rather than remain a spectator.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not push b-pawns and f-pawns without choosing a theater.
TRADE FILTER	Preserve pieces that support e4 and trade defenders of the dark squares only when the center will open in White's favor.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Choose one theater-central expansion or minority attack-and make every piece support that choice before advancing pawns. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not push b-pawns and f-pawns without choosing a theater.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: State White's plan, Black's best counterplay, and the piece that must improve first.

11. QGD Exchange with Nge2 - Break Lab



QGD EXCHANGE AND CARLSBAD

READ THE POSITION

White chooses the flexible Nge2 setup, keeping the f-pawn available for a central or kingside expansion.

PRIMARY PLAN

Do not push b-pawns and f-pawns without choosing a theater.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...c5: Black challenges the center and may equalize quickly.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bg5 Be7 6. e3 O-O 7. Bd3 Nbd7 8. Qc2 Re8 9. Nge2 Nf8 10. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Calculate the central break through the first quiet position.

11. Decision Framework

QGD Exchange with Nge2 - Break Lab

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	White chooses the flexible Nge2 setup, keeping the f-pawn available for a central or kingside expansion.
PIECE JOB	The e2-knight earns its place through g3, f4 or c1; it should support e4 rather than remain a spectator.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not push b-pawns and f-pawns without choosing a theater.
TRADE FILTER	Preserve pieces that support e4 and trade defenders of the dark squares only when the center will open in White's favor.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Choose one theater-central expansion or minority attack-and make every piece support that choice before advancing pawns. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not push b-pawns and f-pawns without choosing a theater.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Calculate the central break through the first quiet position.

12. QGD Exchange with Nf3 - Trade Lab



QGD EXCHANGE AND CARLSBAD

READ THE POSITION

Trade the dark-squared bishops when it improves access to c5 and c7; avoid exchanges that relieve all pressure on c6.

PRIMARY PLAN

Create the c6 weakness with b5, fix it, then transfer pieces to the c-file instead of expecting the pawn push to win by itself. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Ne4: Black trades pieces and reduces queenside pressure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Nf3 c6 6. Bg5 Be7 7. Qc2 O-O 8. e3 Nbd7 9. Bd3 Re8 10. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Approve a trade only after describing the resulting structure and ending.

12. Decision Framework

QGD Exchange with Nf3 - Trade Lab

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	The Nf3 Exchange setup favors reliable development and the classic queenside minority attack.
PIECE JOB	The f3-knight supports a reliable center while rooks and queen prepare the queenside files created by b4-b5.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not launch b4 if Black's central break is faster.
TRADE FILTER	Trade the dark-squared bishops when it improves access to c5 and c7; avoid exchanges that relieve all pressure on c6.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Create the c6 weakness with b5, fix it, then transfer pieces to the c-file instead of expecting the pawn push to win by itself. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not launch b4 if Black's central break is faster.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Approve a trade only after describing the resulting structure and ending.

13. QGD Exchange with Nf3 - Move-Order Lab



QGD EXCHANGE AND CARLSBAD

READ THE POSITION

The Nf3 Exchange setup favors reliable development and the classic queenside minority attack.

PRIMARY PLAN

Nf3 means dependable development and a queenside minority plan.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Ne4: Black trades pieces and reduces queenside pressure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Nf3 c6 6. Bg5 Be7 7. Qc2 O-O 8. e3 Nbd7 9. Bd3 Re8 10. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Reconstruct the line and name the first move-order fork.

13. Decision Framework

QGD Exchange with Nf3 - Move-Order Lab

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	The Nf3 Exchange setup favors reliable development and the classic queenside minority attack.
PIECE JOB	The f3-knight supports a reliable center while rooks and queen prepare the queenside files created by b4-b5.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not launch b4 if Black's central break is faster.
TRADE FILTER	Trade the dark-squared bishops when it improves access to c5 and c7; avoid exchanges that relieve all pressure on c6.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Create the c6 weakness with b5, fix it, then transfer pieces to the c-file instead of expecting the pawn push to win by itself. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not launch b4 if Black's central break is faster.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Reconstruct the line and name the first move-order fork.

14. QGD Exchange with Nf3 - Plan Lab



QGD EXCHANGE AND CARLSBAD

READ THE POSITION

Prepare a3, Rab1, b4, and b5.

PRIMARY PLAN

The f3-knight supports a reliable center while rooks and queen prepare the queenside files created by b4-b5.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Ne4: Black trades pieces and reduces queenside pressure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Nf3 c6 6. Bg5 Be7 7. Qc2 O-O 8. e3 Nbd7 9. Bd3 Re8 10. O-O

MEMORY RULE

State White's plan, Black's best counterplay, and the piece that must improve first.

14. Decision Framework

QGD Exchange with Nf3 - Plan Lab

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	The Nf3 Exchange setup favors reliable development and the classic queenside minority attack.
PIECE JOB	The f3-knight supports a reliable center while rooks and queen prepare the queenside files created by b4-b5.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not launch b4 if Black's central break is faster.
TRADE FILTER	Trade the dark-squared bishops when it improves access to c5 and c7; avoid exchanges that relieve all pressure on c6.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Create the c6 weakness with b5, fix it, then transfer pieces to the c-file instead of expecting the pawn push to win by itself. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not launch b4 if Black's central break is faster.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: State White's plan, Black's best counterplay, and the piece that must improve first.

15. Carlsbad Structure Laboratory - Break Lab



QGD EXCHANGE AND CARLSBAD

READ THE POSITION

White has the c- and d-pawn exchange fixed and usually attacks the queenside with fewer pawns. Black seeks ...c5 or ...e5 to avoid defending a static c6 weakness. White's b-pawn creates the weakness; rooks, knights and queen must attack it afterward.

PRIMARY PLAN

Do not trade every rook before the newly opened c-file can be used.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Ne4: Black trades pieces and reduces queenside pressure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Nf3 c6 6. Bg5 Be7 7. Qc2 O-O 8. e3 Nbd7 9. Bd3 Re8 10. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Calculate the central break through the first quiet position.

15. Decision Framework

Carlsbad Structure Laboratory - Break Lab

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	White has the c- and d-pawn exchange fixed and usually attacks the queenside with fewer pawns. Black seeks ...c5 or ...e5 to avoid defending a static c6 weakness. White's b-pawn creates the weakness; rooks, knights and queen must attack it afterward.
PIECE JOB	The f3-knight supports a reliable center while rooks and queen prepare the queenside files created by b4-b5.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not trade every rook before the newly opened c-file can be used.
TRADE FILTER	Keep pieces that can enter c5, c6 or c7 after b4-b5. Exchange a defender when the c-file target remains and cannot be repaired. Trade the dark-squared bishops when it improves access to c5 and c7; avoid exchanges that relieve all pressure on c6.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Fix the c6 pawn before simplifying. Bring the king toward the queenside once central breaks are controlled. Create a second weakness if Black can defend c6 with one piece.
CLOCK RULE	Do not trade every rook before the newly opened c-file can be used.

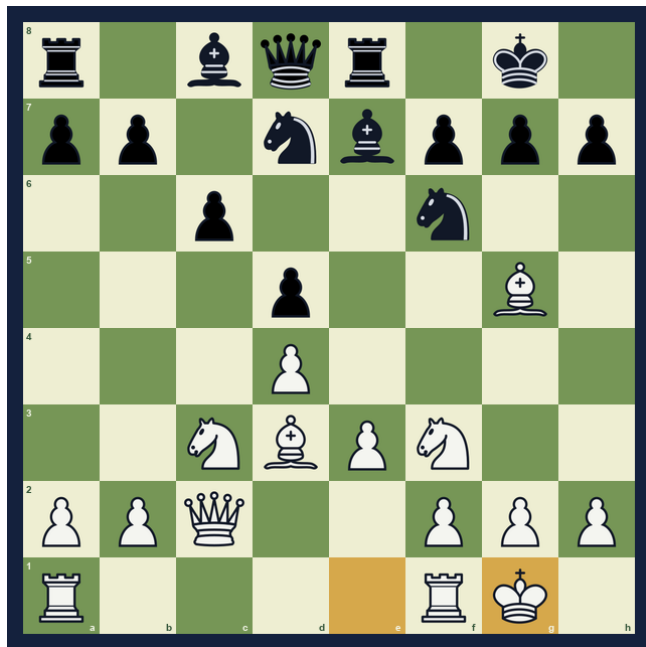
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Calculate the central break through the first quiet position.

16. Carlsbad Structure Laboratory - Endgames - Trade Lab



QGD EXCHANGE AND CARLSBAD

READ THE POSITION

Keep pieces that can enter c5, c6 or c7 after b4-b5. Exchange a defender when the c-file target remains and cannot be repaired. Trade the dark-squared bishops when it improves access to c5 and c7; avoid exchanges that relieve all pressure on c6.

PRIMARY PLAN

Fix the c6 pawn before simplifying. Bring the king toward the queenside once central breaks are controlled. Create a second weakness if Black can defend c6 with one piece.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Ne4: Black trades pieces and reduces queenside pressure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Nf3 c6 6. Bg5 Be7 7. Qc2 O-O 8. e3 Nbd7 9. Bd3 Re8 10. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Approve a trade only after describing the resulting structure and ending.

16. Decision Framework

Carlsbad Structure Laboratory - Endgames - Trade Lab

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	White has the c- and d-pawn exchange fixed and usually attacks the queenside with fewer pawns. Black seeks ...c5 or ...e5 to avoid defending a static c6 weakness. White's b-pawn creates the weakness; rooks, knights and queen must attack it afterward.
PIECE JOB	The f3-knight supports a reliable center while rooks and queen prepare the queenside files created by b4-b5.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not trade every rook before the newly opened c-file can be used.
TRADE FILTER	Keep pieces that can enter c5, c6 or c7 after b4-b5. Exchange a defender when the c-file target remains and cannot be repaired. Trade the dark-squared bishops when it improves access to c5 and c7; avoid exchanges that relieve all pressure on c6.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Fix the c6 pawn before simplifying. Bring the king toward the queenside once central breaks are controlled. Create a second weakness if Black can defend c6 with one piece.
CLOCK RULE	Do not trade every rook before the newly opened c-file can be used.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Approve a trade only after describing the resulting structure and ending.

17. QGD Exchange with Nge2 - Move-Order Lab



QGD EXCHANGE AND CARLSBAD

READ THE POSITION

White chooses the flexible Nge2 setup, keeping the f-pawn available for a central or kingside expansion.

PRIMARY PLAN

Nge2 preserves f3 and points toward e4; choose that plan consciously.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...c5: Black challenges the center and may equalize quickly.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bg5 Be7 6. e3 O-O 7. Bd3 Nbd7 8. Qc2 Re8 9. Nge2 Nf8 10. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Reconstruct the line and name the first move-order fork.

17. Decision Framework

QGD Exchange with Nge2 - Move-Order Lab

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	White chooses the flexible Nge2 setup, keeping the f-pawn available for a central or kingside expansion.
PIECE JOB	The e2-knight earns its place through g3, f4 or c1; it should support e4 rather than remain a spectator.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not push b-pawns and f-pawns without choosing a theater.
TRADE FILTER	Preserve pieces that support e4 and trade defenders of the dark squares only when the center will open in White's favor.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Choose one theater-central expansion or minority attack-and make every piece support that choice before advancing pawns. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not push b-pawns and f-pawns without choosing a theater.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Reconstruct the line and name the first move-order fork.

18. QGD Exchange with Nge2 - Plan Lab



QGD EXCHANGE AND CARLSBAD

READ THE POSITION

Use f3, Rae1, and central support when Black is passive.

PRIMARY PLAN

The e2-knight earns its place through g3, f4 or c1; it should support e4 rather than remain a spectator.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...c5: Black challenges the center and may equalize quickly.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bg5 Be7 6. e3 O-O 7. Bd3 Nbd7 8. Qc2 Re8 9. Nge2 Nf8 10. O-O

MEMORY RULE

State White's plan, Black's best counterplay, and the piece that must improve first.

18. Decision Framework

QGD Exchange with Nge2 - Plan Lab

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	White chooses the flexible Nge2 setup, keeping the f-pawn available for a central or kingside expansion.
PIECE JOB	The e2-knight earns its place through g3, f4 or c1; it should support e4 rather than remain a spectator.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not push b-pawns and f-pawns without choosing a theater.
TRADE FILTER	Preserve pieces that support e4 and trade defenders of the dark squares only when the center will open in White's favor.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Choose one theater-central expansion or minority attack-and make every piece support that choice before advancing pawns. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not push b-pawns and f-pawns without choosing a theater.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: State White's plan, Black's best counterplay, and the piece that must improve first.

19. QGD Exchange with Nge2 - Break Lab



QGD EXCHANGE AND CARLSBAD

READ THE POSITION

White chooses the flexible Nge2 setup, keeping the f-pawn available for a central or kingside expansion.

PRIMARY PLAN

Do not push b-pawns and f-pawns without choosing a theater.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...c5: Black challenges the center and may equalize quickly.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bg5 Be7 6. e3 O-O 7. Bd3 Nbd7 8. Qc2 Re8 9. Nge2 Nf8 10. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Calculate the central break through the first quiet position.

19. Decision Framework

QGD Exchange with Nge2 - Break Lab

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	White chooses the flexible Nge2 setup, keeping the f-pawn available for a central or kingside expansion.
PIECE JOB	The e2-knight earns its place through g3, f4 or c1; it should support e4 rather than remain a spectator.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not push b-pawns and f-pawns without choosing a theater.
TRADE FILTER	Preserve pieces that support e4 and trade defenders of the dark squares only when the center will open in White's favor.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Choose one theater-central expansion or minority attack-and make every piece support that choice before advancing pawns. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not push b-pawns and f-pawns without choosing a theater.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Calculate the central break through the first quiet position.

20. QGD Exchange with Nf3 - Trade Lab



QGD EXCHANGE AND CARLSBAD

READ THE POSITION

Trade the dark-squared bishops when it improves access to c5 and c7; avoid exchanges that relieve all pressure on c6.

PRIMARY PLAN

Create the c6 weakness with b5, fix it, then transfer pieces to the c-file instead of expecting the pawn push to win by itself. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Ne4: Black trades pieces and reduces queenside pressure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Nf3 c6 6. Bg5 Be7 7. Qc2 O-O 8. e3 Nbd7 9. Bd3 Re8 10. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Approve a trade only after describing the resulting structure and ending.

20. Decision Framework

QGD Exchange with Nf3 - Trade Lab

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	The Nf3 Exchange setup favors reliable development and the classic queenside minority attack.
PIECE JOB	The f3-knight supports a reliable center while rooks and queen prepare the queenside files created by b4-b5.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not launch b4 if Black's central break is faster.
TRADE FILTER	Trade the dark-squared bishops when it improves access to c5 and c7; avoid exchanges that relieve all pressure on c6.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Create the c6 weakness with b5, fix it, then transfer pieces to the c-file instead of expecting the pawn push to win by itself. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not launch b4 if Black's central break is faster.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Approve a trade only after describing the resulting structure and ending.

Course Completion Test

Choose ten chapters at random. Rebuild each reference position, name both sides' plans, identify the critical break, and state the trade filter without reopening the chapter.

Score one point for the structure, one for your plan, one for counterplay, one for the break, and one for the memory rule. Forty out of fifty means the knowledge is usable; below forty means retrieval practice should continue.

FINAL PRINCIPLE

A course is complete when its ideas appear in your decisions, not when its pages have been read.